

FROM SCARED TO CONFIDENT

Your first steps towards to solo
female travel



An honest guide to starting solo travel,
whatever age you take the leap.

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Hi,

My name's Abi and for ten years I was the London girl with the solid job, the weekend café routine, and a growing feeling that there had to be more than this. I'd scroll through travel Instagram thinking "they're so brave" and quietly assume that kind of freedom wasn't really built for me.

I'd had the itch to travel more for years, but I didn't have anyone to go with, so I just... didn't. If I'm honest, the thing actually holding me back wasn't safety or money. It was worrying what other people would think.



Eventually the itch won. I booked a flight to Sweden, and in the lead-up I felt nervous, anxious and excited all at once. It's hard to explain the feeling, it's not just fear, it's the fear of the unknown mixed with the genuine excitement of seeing somewhere new and doing it completely on your own terms.

That trip unlocked a confidence I didn't know I had. It taught me that I'm able to adapt, that I can navigate a foreign country where I don't speak the language, trust my own instincts, and let the anxiety I felt just sit there as background noise instead of calling the shots. It taught me that being brave isn't a feeling you wait to arrive. It's what happens when you push yourself out of your comfort zone anyway.

Fast forward to now: I live in Thailand, and solo travel isn't the scary unknown it once was - it's just something I do. This guide is what I wish someone had told me before that first flight.

DISCLAIMER:

This guide contains affiliate links, which means I may earn a small commission if you make a purchase through these links at no extra cost to you. I want to be completely transparent; earning from travel is a real thing. It's something I do myself, and I'm sharing this information because I genuinely believe there's room for us all to benefit from travel opportunities. I only recommend products and services that I genuinely use and believe that you could benefit from them too.

Everything in this guide is intended for informational purposes only.

Abi[♥]





WHAT'S INCLUDED:

Before we get into it, here's what this is actually going to help you do:

- Figure out the fear that's really holding you back - it's usually not the one you think it is
- The Fear Flip: what actually happens with eating alone, safety, age, and judgement
- The Confidence Ladder: small practice steps before you book anything big
- The S.A.F.E. Framework: safety tips that are genuinely useful, not just scary internet advice
- 6 easy destinations to start with if you've got no idea where to go
- AI prompts to help you plan without the overwhelm
- A few honest booking tips and a checklist so you're not googling everything the night before you fly



What You Haven't Said Out Loud

Before flights and packing lists, I want to name the fear underneath your other fears, because it was underneath mine, and nobody warns you about it.

It's not really about getting lost or eating alone. It's the quieter thing: what happens when there's no one left to distract you from your own head. No group chat to hide behind, nothing to perform for, just you and your own thoughts.

For me that showed up as: what if I get there and I'm just bored of myself? What if the silence tells me something I don't want to hear? What if people think it's sad that I'm doing this alone?

Here's what actually happened: the discomfort didn't last long, and it turned into something closer to relief. I stopped narrating my life for an audience and just started living it. Nobody around you is thinking "how sad, all alone" - the reality is they're thinking about their own lunch, their own trip, their own life. The story where everyone's watching and judging you is one your brain tells you at home and it very rarely survives contact with the actual trip.

THE FEAR FLIP

The idea's simple: take the fear, say it in plain words, then flip it against what actually happened. Here's five of mine, flipped:

FEAR #1: "I'll be lonely eating alone and everyone will be staring at me."

REALITY: Breakfast and lunch never bothered me - it was dinner I found hardest. I stuck to casual, fast-food style places for a while because I noticed other people doing the same thing. There was an Italian restaurant I'd seen online and really wanted to try, but when I got there it was way fancier than I expected, and I chickened out. I ended up ordering a pizza to take away and ate it back in my hotel room instead.

Here's the flip: almost nobody was actually looking. People are wrapped up in their own conversations, their own phones, their own food. Since then, i'm pleased to say now I'll eat wherever I want, regardless of the situation. It took me a while to get there but what i've learnt is that it's completely fine to take baby steps. If something feels too uncomfortable, adapt to the situation and do what feels right for you in that moment.

FEAR #2: "What if something goes wrong and there's no one there to help me"

REALITY: In my experience, people are generally happy to help - one of the worst case scenarios is that they just can't. I got lost in the Stockholm subway once and a stranger not only redirected me but pointed me to a cute café I'd never have found myself. Use your judgement on who you approach - uniformed staff or someone with family nearby is a safer bet, but the instinct that's kept you safe at home doesn't switch off abroad.

FEAR #3: "I'm too old for this - solo travel is a gap year thing"

REALITY: I see age as an advantage now, not a barrier. Generally speaking, as you get older, you have a little more disposable income and get to a point where you can afford nicer stays. Having said that, it's really about your personal preference. There are plenty of solo travellers in their 30's/40's/50's that still stay in hostels and love it. What matters is picking accommodation you actually feel comfortable in, and remembering you're never stuck: shorten a stay or extend it as you go.

FEAR #4: "People will think it's sad that I'm doing this by myself."

REALITY: This was my biggest fear to begin with, but you know what? Nobody's actually ever said it to my face. It was an imagined opinion running the whole show in my head, not a real one. The people who'd judge you for travelling alone were never going to be the ones cheering you on anyway - so their opinion is costing you a trip for nothing, while the people who actually love you just want to see you happy.

FEAR #5: ""I'll get there and realise I've made a huge mistake."

REALITY: First of all you don't know that for sure. That's your brain trying to protect you. If you reframe it, that gut-drop feeling is jet lag and decision fatigue talking, not a verdict on your trip. Give it 48 hours before deciding anything. Almost everything feels different once you've slept, eaten properly and found your bearings, and you can always change plans after that if it's still not right.



THE CONFIDENCE LADDER

Confidence isn't something you wait to feel, it's something you build, one small deliberate step at a time. This is the ladder I climbed, and the one I still use before anything that scares me. You don't have to go from zero to a two-week solo trip overnight. Here's the idea: take something you'd normally do with a friend, partner or family member and do it alone instead. Each step makes the next slightly easier:

- Get a coffee alone and actually stay to drink it - no phone as a shield
- Eat a meal alone somewhere in your own city
- Go to the cinema, a museum, or an event by yourself
- Take a day trip alone somewhere new but nearby
- Book a solo weekend away within your own country
- Try a short weekend abroad somewhere easy - it's often a bigger confidence jump than the flight itself

From there, build up gradually: longer trips, new destinations, further from home each time.

Keep a journal or notes on your phone as you go, and jot down how each one actually felt. It becomes real evidence, in your own words, that you can do this, so by the time you're booking the trip you've been dreaming about, you'll already know you can.



THE S.A.F.E. FRAMEWORK

Four letters, so the safety basics actually stick, without turning into a checklist of fear.

S - Share Your Plan

Send your full itinerary and check in daily with someone from home. Set up live location sharing with someone you trust for the duration of your trip.

A - Arrange the Essentials

Book a transfer in advance from the airport the day you land, so you're not arriving late and picking up a random taxi. Back up photos or PDFs of your passport, bookings and insurance, all saved offline. Learn basic phrases such as: please, thank you, and how much in the local language. This helps more than you think.

F - Follow Your Gut

Check reviews that specifically mention solo women. If something feels wrong, you're allowed to leave - no explanation needed. Trust your gut over politeness, every time.

E - Ease Off the Extras

You don't need 47 safety gadgets, a 5-star-only rule, or a blanket ban on street food and local transport. Most places are safer than an anxious brain thinks - common sense beats hypervigilance every time.



WHERE TO START: 6 BEGINNER FRIENDLY DESTINATIONS

One of the biggest blockers to actually booking anything is decision paralysis - too many options, no idea where to even start looking. So here's my shortlist: places I've actually been, picked for being easy to navigate solo, safe, and make for a great first trip. Pick one that pulls at you and go from there.



Barcelona, Spain

Vibrant and walkable, with a brilliant social energy that makes it easy to meet other travellers. Gaudí's architecture, tapas bars, and the Gothic Quarter are all easily doable alone. Plus you get the best of both worlds - beach and city!



Amsterdam, Netherlands

Compact, safe, and incredibly easy to get around. Nobody bats an eyelid at a woman dining solo - the whole city has a relaxed, open atmosphere that makes travelling alone feel completely natural.



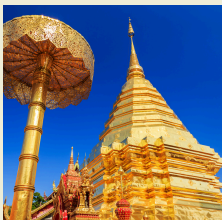
Prague, Czech Republic

Affordable, beautiful, and has a real sense of safety. It's actually been ranked the number one city in the world for solo female travel, and the hostel scene makes it easy to meet people.



Bangkok, Thailand

This is where I live now. It's vibrant, affordable, well-connected, and feels safe day to day. Getting around is simple on the BTS Skytrain, MRT, or Grab. Plus the people are so welcoming it's hard not to feel at home.



Chiang Mai, Thailand

Slower and cooler than Bangkok, with a huge community of like-minded travellers and easy opportunities to meet people, especially around the co-working café scene.



London, England

The place I grew up in. Stick to the main tourist hubs and it makes for a brilliant weekend with genuinely loads to do. Just keep an eye on your belongings, as you would in any big city.



LET AI DO THE PLANNING

You don't need to be a planning wizard, you just need the right prompts. Copy these into your AI search tool of choice, swap in your own details, and let it do the research:

Prompts to help you get started

Prompt 1 - Picking where to go:

I want to take a solo trip with a budget of about £[X] for [X] days. Compare [destination A] and [destination B] for flight and accommodation costs, and tell me which is easier for a first-time solo traveller.

Prompt 2 - Visa & safety:

I'm a first-time solo traveller visiting [destination] as a [nationality] passport holder. What visa do I need, which areas are best to stay in for safety and transport, and what should I check before booking flights?

Prompt 3 - Booking smart:

I'm about to book flights to [destination] for [month]. What's typically the cheapest way to book, and what should I look for in a travel insurance policy for a solo trip?

Prompt 4 - Building your itinerary:

Create a loose [X]-day itinerary for [destination] with 2-3 highlights per day. Include suggestions for day trips where possible, and leave free time to wander. Flag anything that needs booking in advance, and suggest public transport or walking routes where possible.

Prompt 5 - Packing:

I'm packing for a solo [X]-day trip to [destination] in [season]. Give me a light packing list, plus anything specific to the climate or local customs I should know.



If your plans need extra gear - day hikes, beach days, long transits etc, I've put together an Amazon storefront with all the travel essentials I actually use and would pack again.

Take a look - you might find something you didn't know you needed!



Booking Tips

The technique behind each booking matters more than which app you use - these are the habits that actually save money and hassle. Quick honesty check: some of the links below are affiliate links, meaning I earn a small commission if you book through them - at no extra cost to you. I only recommend things I've genuinely used.

- Never book the first price you see. Compare at least two search engines before booking. The same flight or stay can be £30-50 cheaper on one than another. Set a price alert and track it for a week or two before committing, since fares fluctuate.
- For stays, I use [Booking.com](#). If you're looking to make friends, or on a bit of a tight budget, I would recommend [Hostel World](#). You can book private rooms so you have the safety net of your own space, but social common areas and in most cases, organised group activities.
- Check reviews properly: Read the most recent 10 reviews, not the overall score - a high rating can easily be skewed. Look to make sure the feedback is consistent.
- Sort your money early: Set up a fee-free card before you travel, not the week before - verification can sometimes take a few days. I use [Monzo](#) and always carry a backup card too, as well as cash.
- Get connected before you land: Buy an eSIM before you land, not after. Trying to sort data at arrivals can be more stressful than it needs to be. I use [Airalo](#) to stay connected and you can easily top up if you need more.
- Book ahead for busy attractions. Booking skip-the-line tickets in advance saves real queue time at popular sites, even if you're not usually a planner. I use [GetYourGuide](#) to join group trips with other solo travellers. It's a great way to meet other people and see the sights at the same time!
- Don't skip travel insurance. You should sort it as soon as you book your flights, not the week before, regardless of how long you're going for. I use [VisitorsCoverage](#).

THE PRE-FLIGHT CHECKLIST

Everything from the S.A.F.E. Framework and the booking tips, compiled into one list. Some of these need sorting weeks ahead - passport and insurance especially, so don't leave the whole list for the last minute. But tick through it all before you fly, and you can stop replaying it in your head:

- ☐ Passport valid for 6+ months from your return date
- ☐ Travel insurance booked and confirmation saved offline
- ☐ Full itinerary shared with someone at home
- ☐ Offline maps and a translation app downloaded
- ☐ eSIM or local SIM sorted before you land
- ☐ Backup card plus some cash in local currency
- ☐ Accommodation address and first-night transfer saved offline
- ☐ Emergency contacts and your embassy's number saved in your phone



YOUR FIRST STEPS

Now you've read through this, hopefully you've got the tools you need to identify what's actually holding you back - whether that's the fear you've finally said out loud, the practical stuff that felt scarier in your head than it is in reality, or just not knowing where to start.

You've got a way to build confidence in small steps, a way to stay safe without living in fear, and a way to plan without it taking over your life. What's left isn't more research. It's the confidence to actually go and book that trip.

Pick one destination that excites you - not the "perfect" one, just one that makes you curious. I started exactly where you are: scared, overthinking, making excuses, waiting for someone to tell me it was safe to go. Nobody ever really does.

The difference between dreaming and doing is one decision, made before you feel ready, not after.

If you need a bit of help along the way, here's where to go:

- **First Solo Trip Confidence Session:** A 1-hour, one-on-one call - perfect if you've researched everything but still can't bring yourself to book. We'll talk honestly about what's actually scaring you, I'll share what worked for me, and we'll map out your realistic next steps together. It's not therapy, and it's not trip planning. It's also not a guarantee you'll never feel nervous again - honestly, I still do sometimes but I've been exactly where you are - [£35 BOOK HERE](#)
- **Want destination inspiration?** Read my [destination guides](#). These are my genuine experiences from places that I've visited and might give you some inspo!

And if you've ever wondered whether travel could pay you back - that's a guide of its own. Keep an eye on @always.go.anywhere for it.

What's your first destination going to be?

